HAMBURG, GERMANY

Hamburger Kunsthalle: Masterpieces

Twenty works about access to a figure, a landscape or a public space.



Nana turns away from her mirror and meets the viewer's gaze. Friedrich's wanderer does the reverse: he faces the landscape and keeps his face unavailable. These two famous figures establish different terms for looking. One acknowledges a presence outside the picture; the other offers a position from which to approach a view while withholding a personal response to it.

The rest of this selection extends the question into gardens, workplaces and places of entertainment. People may be absorbed in tasks, identified by uniforms, or crowded into a performance. Landscape can conceal as much as it reveals. The guide follows what each picture makes accessible and what remains beyond its visible evidence.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/hamburger-kunsthalle

The selection · 20

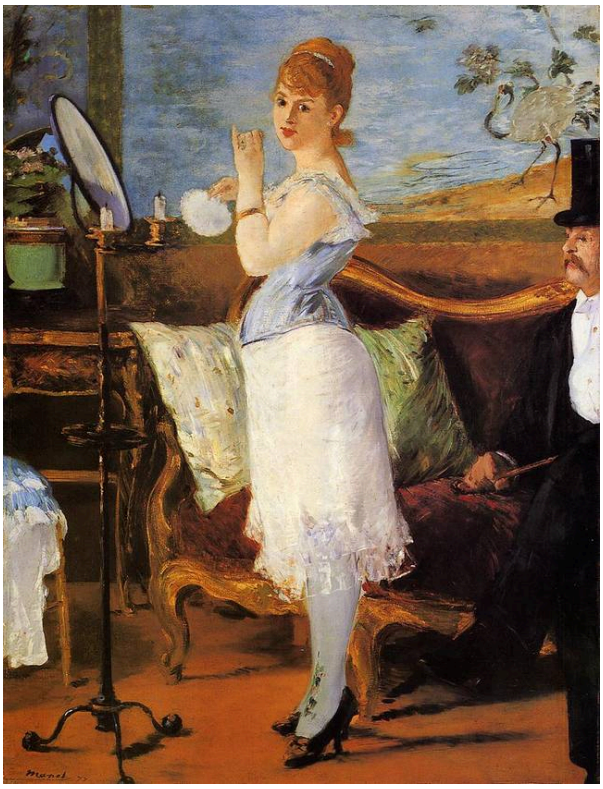
1. Nana
   Édouard Manet · 1877
2. Wanderer above the Sea of Fog
   Caspar David Friedrich · 1818
3. Adoration of the Child
   Master Francke · c. 1426
4. Bluxao V
   Willi Baumeister · 1955
5. Eve
   Henri Rousseau · c.1906 - 1907
6. Swift Hope
   René Magritte · 1928
7. Amsterdam Orphan Girls in the Garden
   Max Liebermann · 1885
8. The Net Menders
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9. View from Pimonte over the Bay of Naples
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11. The Surgeon Ferdinand Sauerbruch
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12. The Terrace of the Hotel Louis C. Jacob
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13. Head of a Child
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15. Inside the Palm House on the Pfaueninsel
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16. The Twelve-Year-Old Jesus in the Temple
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17. Mother and Child
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18. Nordic Landscape
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19. Old Peasant Woman
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20. Sea Lions in the Circus
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01 / 20

Nana

Édouard Manet

1877 · Oil on canvas · Hamburger Kunsthalle



Édouard Manet. Nana. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/edouard-manet/nana-1877 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The mirror is no longer the woman's focus: she turns towards the viewer. At the side, the seated man is only partly admitted into the frame. Manet gives the two figures unequal visibility and makes looking an event within the dressing scene. Nana is not simply available for inspection; her outward gaze interrupts that comfortable arrangement.

Object source · Open artwork

02 / 20

Wanderer above the Sea of Fog

Caspar David Friedrich

1818 · Hamburger Kunsthalle



Caspar David Friedrich. The Wanderer Above the Sea of Fog. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The man's firm footing contrasts with the mist that hides much of the terrain. His back provides a bodily position from which to approach the view, but his expression cannot tell us how to interpret it. Friedrich joins apparent command to incomplete knowledge. Standing high does not make the landscape fully available.

Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

Adoration of the Child

Master Francke

c. 1426 · Tempera on oak · Hamburger Kunsthalle



Master Francke. Adoration of the Child. WikiArt source label: Master Francke Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/master-francke/adoration-of-the-child · Master Francke Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

Rich colour and pattern could disperse attention across the surface. The kneeling figures bring it back towards the newborn child. Master Francke uses bodily direction to organise a setting that is also conspicuously decorative. The small central group does not have to occupy most of the panel to determine the surrounding figures' purpose.

Object source · Open artwork

04 / 20

Bluxao V

Willi Baumeister

1955 · Oil on cardboard · Hamburger Kunsthalle



Willi Baumeister. Bluxao V. WikiArt source label: Willi Baumeister Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/willi-baumeister/bluxao-v-1955 · Willi Baumeister Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

Bright extensions pull away from the darker central forms in several directions. Their weight and placement establish a balance that remains active against the blue ground. Baumeister permits a suggestion of a figure without requiring every part to acquire an anatomical name. Relations among colours are sufficient to sustain the arrangement.

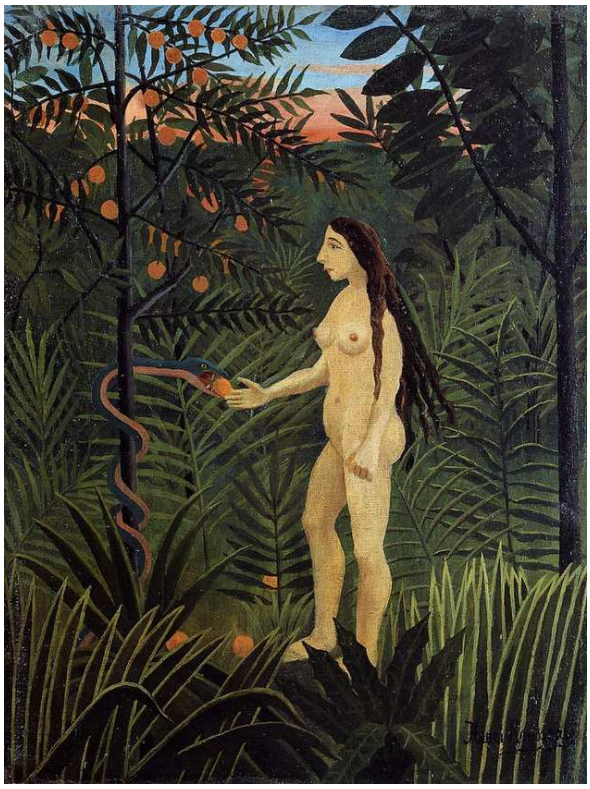
Object source · Open artwork

05 / 20

Eve

Henri Rousseau

c.1906 - 1907 · Oil on canvas · Hamburger Kunsthalle



Henri Rousseau. Eve. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/henri-rousseau/eve-1907 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Leaves and fruit form something closer to an enclosing screen than a distant garden. Rousseau separates the repeated plant shapes clearly, giving vegetation an order as conspicuous as Eve and the snake. The biblical setting is constructed through accumulation. Depth matters less than the density of a world whose parts remain individually legible.

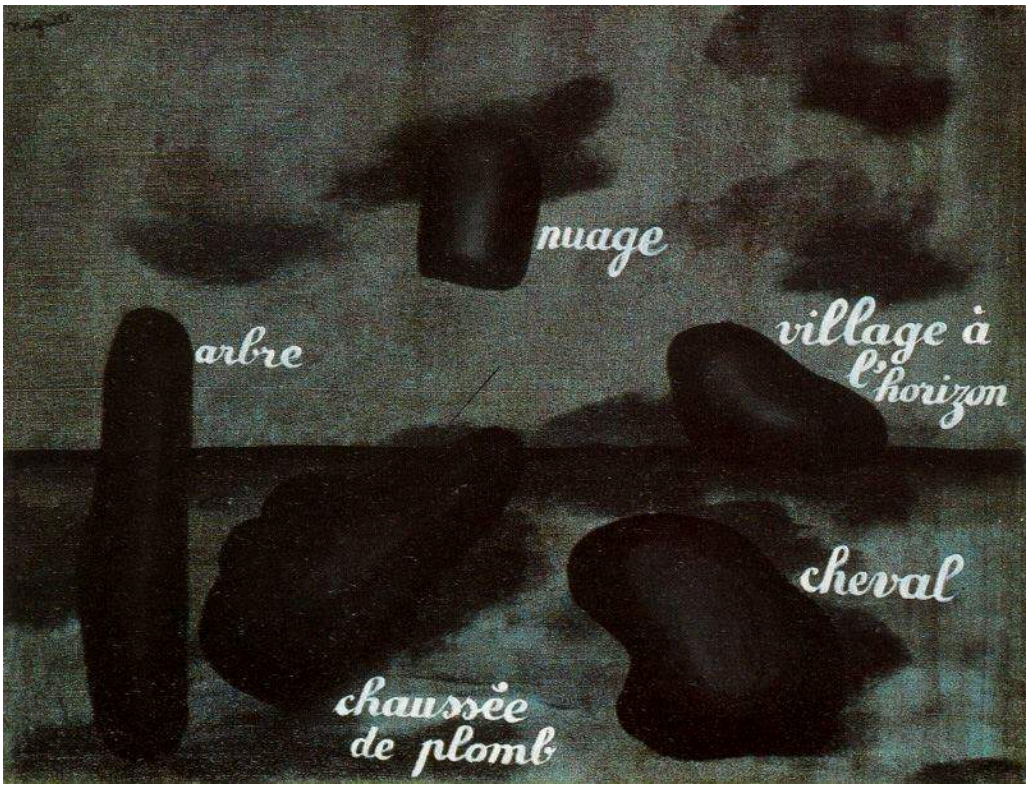
Object source · Open artwork

06 / 20

Swift Hope

René Magritte

1928 · Oil on canvas · Hamburger Kunsthalle



René Magritte. Swift Hope. WikiArt source label: Rene Magritte Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/rene-magritte/swift-hope-1928 · Rene Magritte Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

The words offer names, but the nearby shapes do not obediently illustrate them. Magritte interrupts a routine agreement between reading and seeing. A label may direct attention without supplying a dependable identification. The painting is useful precisely where that agreement fails: it exposes the extra act of interpretation hidden inside apparently straightforward naming.

Object source · Open artwork

07 / 20

Amsterdam Orphan Girls in the Garden

Max Liebermann

1885 · Oil on canvas · Hamburger Kunsthalle



WikiArt. Public domain. Full source frame preserved; proportional resize and JPEG compression. · Public domain

Uniform dresses and aprons establish the girls as a group, while their hands attend to separate pieces of work. Birds add less regulated movement on the ground. Liebermann allows institutional routine and garden activity to occupy the same space. Similar clothing does not make the figures identical in their actions or attention.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: HK-1584

08 / 20

The Net Menders

Max Liebermann

1887–1889 · Hamburger Kunsthalle



Max Liebermann. The Net Menders. Image credit: Max Liebermann; anagoria. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:1888_Liebermann_Die_Netzflickerinnen_anagoria.JPG. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · Public domain

The shared task spreads across open ground rather than gathering around one central workstation. A standing foreground figure establishes scale, while other positions show different parts of the labour. Liebermann gives repetitive work a broad setting without converting it into a single emblematic gesture. The nets connect actions that remain individually distinct.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1580

09 / 20

View from Pimonte over the Bay of Naples

Johan Christian Dahl

1821 · Hamburger Kunsthalle



Johan Christian Dahl. Blick von Pimonte auf die Bucht von Neapel. Image credit: Johan Christian Dahl; Source credit: Photographer and uploader was Hajotthu at de.wikipedia. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Foreground rocks, trees and travellers make the distant bay measurable. Smoke rising from the volcano introduces activity into what might otherwise appear a settled prospect. Dahl holds near and far together without giving them equal detail. The broad view includes a force whose presence can be registered from a distance but not fully inspected.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: HK-5612

10 / 20

Boats on the Beach

Max Beckmann

1937 · Hamburger Kunsthalle



Max Beckmann. Boats on the beach. Image credit: Max Beckmann. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Dark outlines give sails, hulls and people a comparable insistence. Beckmann compresses the beach into wedges and curves against strong areas of sand and water. The spaces between boats matter as much as individual vessels: they are where figures must fit. The shore feels constructed from interlocking shapes rather than opening freely into distance.

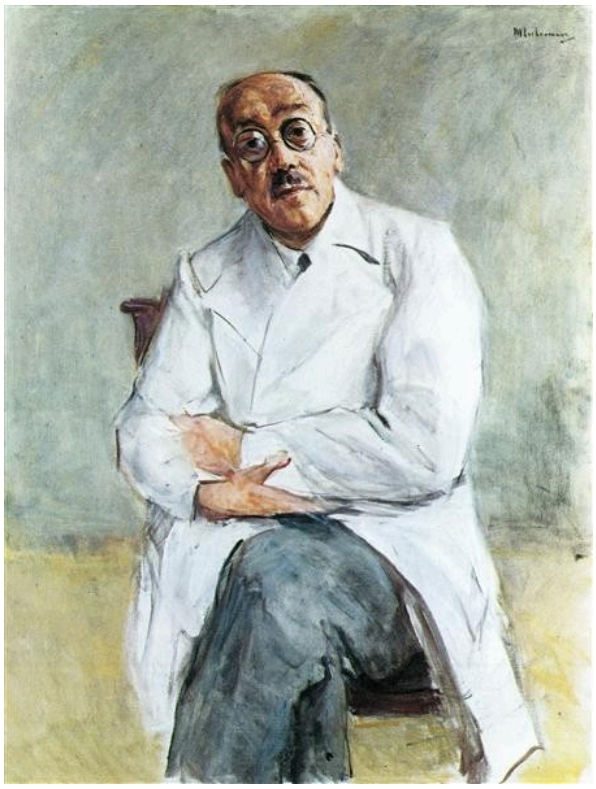
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: HK-200626

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The Surgeon Ferdinand Sauerbruch

Max Liebermann

1932 · Oil on canvas · Hamburger Kunsthalle



WikiArt. Public domain. Full source frame preserved; proportional resize and JPEG compression. · Public domain

The white coat identifies a profession without requiring an operation or an array of instruments. Against pale surroundings, the turn of the head concentrates attention on the sitter. Liebermann keeps role and likeness distinguishable. The coat tells us what kind of authority is being presented; the particular face cannot be reduced to that public sign.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: HK-2927

12 / 20

The Terrace of the Hotel Louis C. Jacob

Max Liebermann

1902 · Oil; canvas (painting support) · Hamburger Kunsthalle



WikiArt. Public domain. Full source frame preserved; proportional resize and JPEG compression. · Public domain

Tables, chairs and tree trunks give the terrace a repeated structure. Patches of light and shade loosen that framework as it recedes beside the river. Liebermann makes public leisure depend on an ordered space that can still accommodate separate groups. The scene's ease is supported by the arrangement rather than explained through imagined conversations.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: HK-1597

13 / 20

Head of a Child

Albrecht Dürer

1520 · Hamburger Kunsthalle



Head of a child. WikiArt; Albrecht Dürer. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

Closed eyes and slightly parted lips establish a passing bodily state without explaining its cause. Dürer gives curling hair and smooth cheeks different kinds of marks, making the act of drawing visible alongside the face. The isolated head invites close observation. A surrounding story would add information, but it is not needed to make the study particular.

Object source · Open artwork

14 / 20

Hamburg after the Fire of 1842

Jacob Gensler

1842 · Hamburger Kunsthalle



Jacob Gensler. Hamburg after the Fire of 1842. Image credit: Jacob Gensler; Source credit: ~. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The damaged city is described partly through newly open space. Surviving masonry and scattered remains frame a view that destruction has made possible. Gensler's small figures measure that exposure. The scene records more than individual ruined buildings: it shows how loss changes the relation between the foreground, the water and what can now be seen beyond.

Object source · Open artwork

15 / 20

Inside the Palm House on the Pfaueninsel

Carl Blechen

1832–1834 · Hamburger Kunsthalle



Carl Blechen. Inside the Palm House on the Pfaueninsel near Potsdam. Image credit: Carl Blechen. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Palm leaves cross the glazed building's framework, setting two kinds of structure against one another. Small figures beneath the plants make their scale apparent. Blechen's interior is both cultivated vegetation and elaborate architecture. The greenhouse does not disappear behind its contents; its visible construction helps explain the conditions under which this indoor abundance can exist.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1324

16 / 20

The Twelve-Year-Old Jesus in the Temple

Max Liebermann

1879 · Oil; canvas (painting support) · Hamburger Kunsthalle



Max Liebermann; Hamburger Kunsthalle, online Sammlung. Public domain. Full source frame preserved; proportional resize and JPEG compression. · Public domain

A boy addresses men whose age, books and clothing suggest established authority. Their close grouping turns the religious subject into a visible exchange of speaking and listening. Liebermann makes the difference in age consequential through position and response. The scene's tension comes from who receives attention, not simply from the number of people present.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: HK-5424

17 / 20

Mother and Child

Paula Modersohn-Becker

c. 1903 · Hamburger Kunsthalle



Paula Modersohn-Becker. Mother and Child. Image credit: Paula Modersohn-Becker; Source credit: Hamburger Kunsthalle, Onlinesammlung. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The pair's joined shapes make holding the central fact of the picture. Broad colour areas give the bodies weight while limiting the amount of facial explanation. Modersohn-Becker does not need a conspicuously sentimental expression to establish care. The physical relation between the larger body and the child supplies an intelligible structure on its own.

Object source · Open artwork

18 / 20

Nordic Landscape

Johan Christian Dahl

1822 · Hamburger Kunsthalle



Johan Christian Dahl. Nordic Landscape. Image credit: Johan Christian Dahl; Source credit: Photographer and uploader was Hajotthu at de.wikipedia. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The bright distance must be reached through close woodland, fallen timber and rough ground. Dahl makes these obstacles part of the view rather than clearing them away for a pleasing prospect. Near textures and distant light require different attention. The landscape offers an opening, but the foreground continues to assert its material presence.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: HK-1063

19 / 20

Old Peasant Woman

Paula Modersohn-Becker

c. 1903 · Hamburger Kunsthalle



Paula Modersohn-Becker. Old Peasant Woman. Image credit: Paula Modersohn-Becker. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

One hand supports the head while the other arm crosses the body. These substantial forms give the portrait its organisation before any interpretation of expression. Modersohn-Becker keeps the clothing dark and the face plainly stated. The supported posture can be observed without turning it into an invented diagnosis of exhaustion, resignation or the sitter's whole life.

Object source · Open artwork

20 / 20

Sea Lions in the Circus

Max Beckmann

1928 · Hamburger Kunsthalle



Max Beckmann. Sea lions in the circus. Image credit: Max Beckmann. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Hoops, animals and coloured structures compete inside the narrow format. Beckmann's heavy contours keep them readable while making the performance space feel tightly packed. Entertainment appears as an arrangement of bodies and equipment with little spare room. The scene's energy is inseparable from these restrictions rather than being a simple image of unrestricted movement.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: HK-5046

Notice the terms of access

Compare Nana's outward glance with the wanderer's hidden face, then consider how uniforms and professional clothing change the other portraits. This is a collection selection, not a guarantee of current display. Check availability when planning a visit around a particular work.

Further reading

Concerning the Spiritual in Art

Wassily Kandinsky; translated by Michael Sadleir · Read free · English

Kandinsky’s discussion of colour and form gives context for the abstract and expressionist works here. Read it as one artist’s argument, then compare it with Baumeister, Beckmann and Modersohn-Becker’s very different pictures.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12

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